



Department
for Work &
Pensions

Services
Week

2026

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Department for Work and Pensions

**Services
Week**
2026

How a service designer can contribute to accessibility

“Personalised public services”

An invite to explore how services can be designed around the individual needs, circumstances and experiences of the people who use them...

+ people who are delivering them

+ those involved in designing them

What I will take you through

- how we created the guidance
- making your service accessible
- design communication
- designing together
- key takeaways and resources

About me

- my pronouns are she/her
- have been a software developer
- a UX designer and researcher
- now a service designer
- very keen on accessibility and inclusion



**Each role in a multi-disciplinary
team has a part to play to avoid
making a service inaccessible**

DWP Accessibility manual

How we created the guidance for
the service designer role



Accessibility in government

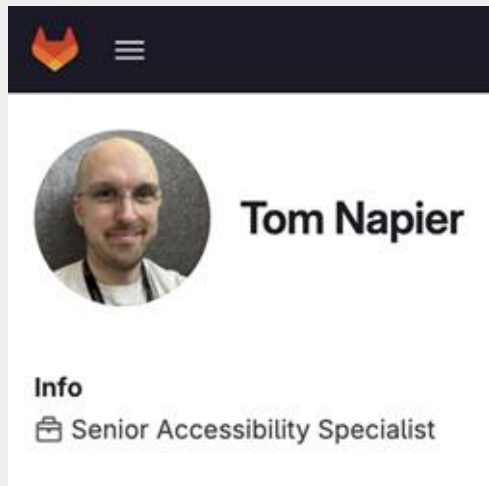
Organisations: [Civil Service](#)

Why we've created an accessibility manual – and how you can help shape it

[Craig Abbott, DWP Digital](#), 27 May 2021 - [Accessibility](#)



Joining DWP in 2023



2 reasons:

- not enough time
- unsure what a service designer does

The service designer role



Service Standard

5. Make sure everyone can use the service

Provide a service that everyone can use, including disabled people and people with other legally protected characteristics. And people who do not have access to the internet or lack the skills or confidence to use it.



Department
for Education

Apply the Service Standard



Government Digital and Data Profession Capability Framework

Service designer

Find out what a service designer in government does.

My own practice

Involving the Service Design Community



What the guidance covers

- WCAG Conformance
- Non-digital accessibility
- Design communication
- Design together
- When you can't make a part of your service accessible



This manual is a community effort. [Email your feedback](#) to help us to improve it.

[Accessibility law](#)

[Guidance for your job role](#)

[Best practice](#)

Service Designer

As a Service Designer, you'll have an overview of an entire end-to-end service, back to front. You'll design journeys across both digital and offline channels. That means you'll be able to consider how accessibility is impacted across the whole service.

You should ensure your designs meet accessibility standards. You should familiarise yourself with:

- the [Web Content Accessibility Guidelines \(WCAG\)](#)
- the [Cognitive accessibility guidelines \(COGA\)](#)

Both are published by the [World Wide Web Consortium \(W3C\)](#).

You should also have an understanding of the different ways that users access content and be able to explain ways to meet those requirements.

In Government, services we build must be accessible to everyone who needs them. This includes public servants too. As a Service Designer, you will be designing a service that may be used by external people or staff, or both.

Your overview of the end-to-end service may give you an insight into inclusivity for both external and internal users. Others on your team might not have this insight, so you should be an advocate in your team for all your users.

You can read more about the role of Service Designer on the [Government Digital and Data Profession Capability Framework](#).

What's different in this role?

- “Your overview of the end-to-end service may give you an insight into inclusivity for both external and internal users”
- “You’ll design journeys across both digital and offline channels”
- Non digital accessibility → [Accessible events toolkit](#) from [Scope](#)

When you can't make part of your service accessible

- a service, technically accessible online might not be the best solution
- you can and should ask for help from accessibility specialists

Accessibility

1 in 4 people are disabled in the UK

vision



hearing



speech



motor



cognitive



It's different for everyone

Defining accessibility

“Accessibility means that people can do what they need to do in a similar amount of time and effort as someone that does not have a disability.

It means that people are empowered and can be independent.”

Source: [GOV.UK Blog post](#)

Web Content Accessibility Guidelines

→ Standard you need to comply with for digital accessibility

Currently, version 2.2

[Web Content Accessibility Guidelines \(WCAG\)](#)

Published by the [World Wide Web Consortium \(W3C\)](#)

Cognitive Accessibility Guidelines (COGA)

→ set of guidelines for inclusive design

Also published by the W3C.

[Nice COGA version by the Department for Education](#)

Neurodiversity

- Dyslexia
- Autism
- ADHD (= Attention Deficit and Hyperactivity Disorder)
- Dyspraxia
- Dyscalculia
- OCD (Obsessive Compulsive Disorder)
- Tourette's syndrome and more

How neurodiversity affects people

- think, process information and language
- interact socially and communicate with others
- perceive space and time

1 in 7 people are neurodivergent

This is about 15 to 20% of the general population
But it's often underestimated and under-declared.

It's much higher for people working in Tech.

→ above 20% and **probably up to 50% in tech** and the
creative industry

Designing for everyone

General recommendations

1 in 4 people
are disabled

- think of accessibility right from the start
- involve disabled people at every stage of your research
- don't forget internal users
- everyone in your team needs to be involved
- ask for feedback (accessible and not only online)

Numbers

Low numeracy affects half the working-age adults in the UK

[Accessible numbers project](#)

by Laura Parker

Designing for users with dyscalculia or low numeracy



Do...

round numbers to the nearest whole number



leave space around numbers



fill in the information you already have



use sentences to add context about numbers

1 in 20
people have
dyscalculia

let people include spaces when entering numbers

12 34 56

user research with people who struggle with numbers



Do not...

use decimals unless it's money



overwhelm people with too much content



expect users to repeat or remember numbers



use tables and grids without explaining what the numbers mean

2231
2578
11

rush users to enter a number accurately



force people to enter a number or do a sum to verify themselves



End-to-End, Back to front

- Integration with other services
- Asking Questions
- Consistency
- Service features guidance in the manual
 - Redundant entry
 - Accessible authentication success criteria

Design communication

Some basic steps

- Use legible fonts, and structure your text with the right headings
- check colour contrast especially for your text
- do not rely on colour alone to convey meaning
- use plain language and explain acronyms
- be careful with numbers
- use accessibility checkers for your slides
- send your presentation ahead of the meeting when possible

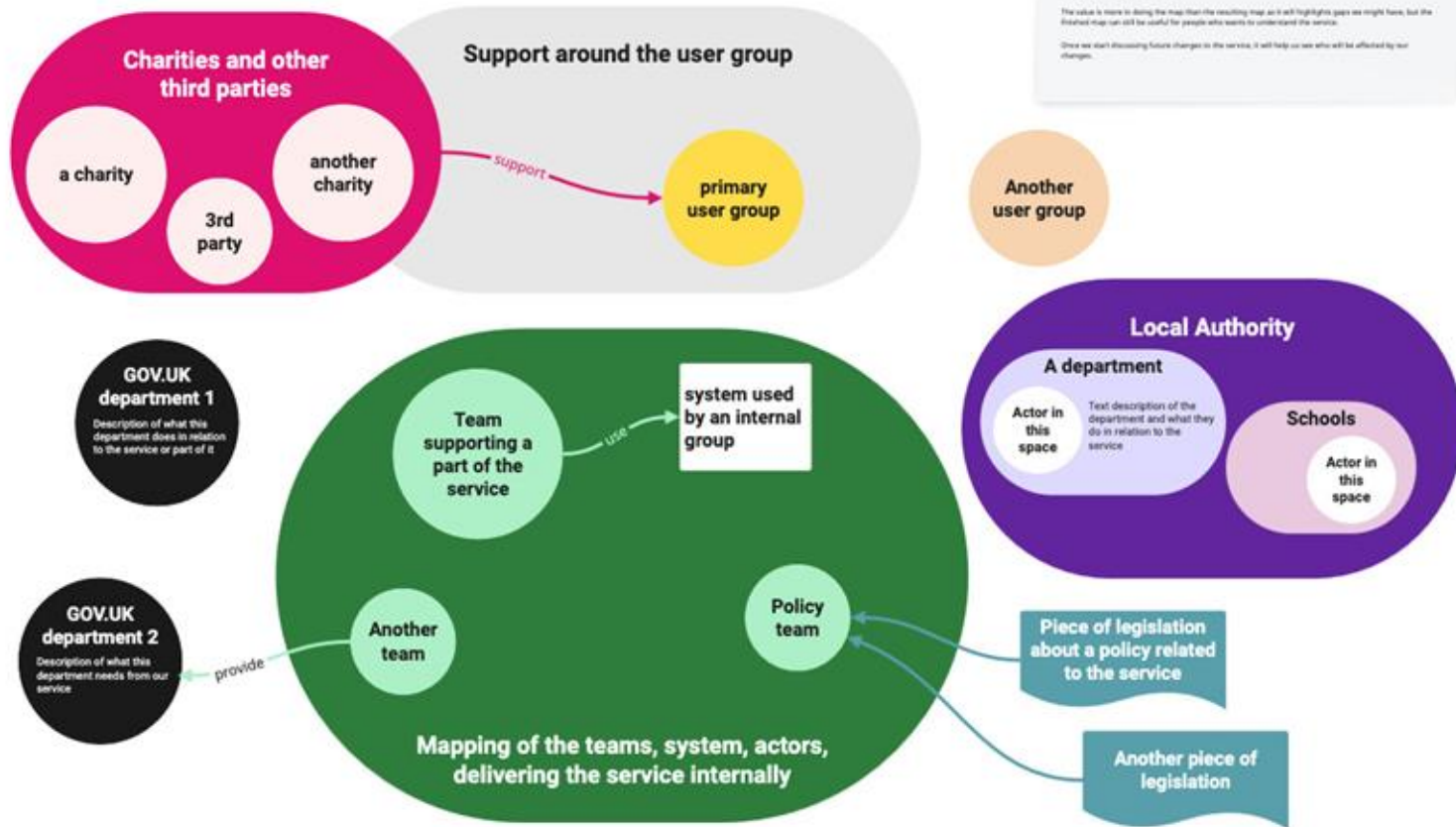
Maps

- colour contrast are still important, and not just for the text
- legible font is still important, but more flexibility on the size
- beware: people will look for meaning in colours and alignment
- not too much info, not too many colours and shapes
- who is your audience? what's your intent?
- create alternative formats

Example:

Mapping an ecosystem

Ecosystem of the service v1.3



Example: Turning the ecosystem visual into a deck (1)

Name of the service or project

Ecosystem of the service v1.3

Last updated 03/09/2025

What is an ecosystem map

Explanation of the purpose of this type of map

Setting expectations

How to read this map

If people still want to understand and use the visual

Ecosystem of the service v1.3



Description of the map

Example: Turning the ecosystem visual into a deck (2)

Our users

Primary users

Another group of users

Charities and third parties

Charity 1

Explain their role
Provide links

Example: Turning the ecosystem visual into a deck (3)

The delivery of the service internally

An area of the department

Description of the team and what they do

Policy - Legal

Description of the teams

Provide links to relevant policies and legislations

Systems and tools

Names, descriptions
Who use them

We welcome your feedback

Contact name@dept.gov.uk

Thank you!

Example: A service map

Service Map v1.5

last updated
03/09/25

Checked by
stakeholders

Key

a step

a task

state

comment for external

comment for internal

state

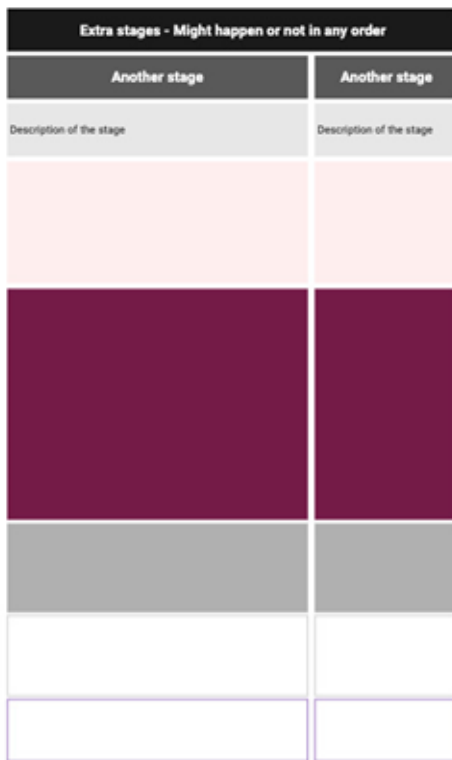
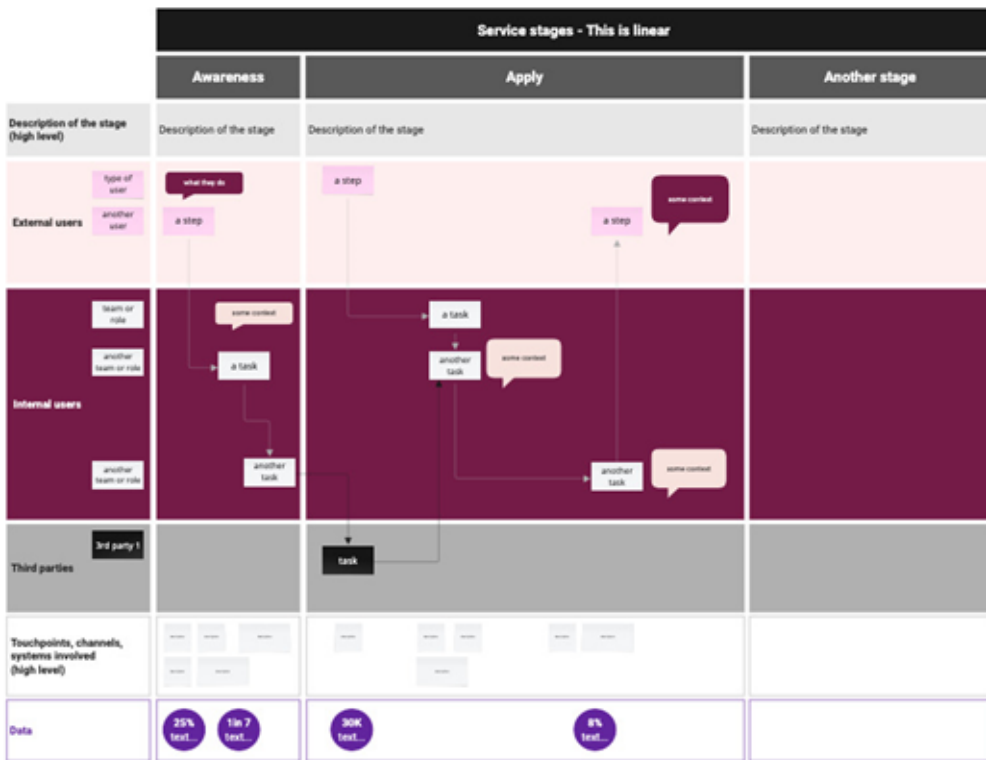
What is a service map?

A service map shows everything needed to maintain the live service with external users and includes the moving parts across the business.

We are mapping across various service stages and for each stage, we provide:

- a high-level description of what this stage is about
- the main tasks/steps for external users: [list them]
- the main tasks/steps for internal users: [list them]
- the main tasks/steps for 3rd parties: [list them]
- high-level technology/system involved - touchpoint and channels

This will be used as a support for discussion with various actors to help us understand what people are doing, when, with who and what tool or system.



Example: Turning the service map visual into a deck (1)

Name of the service or project

Service map v1.5

Last updated 03/09/2025

What is a service map

Explanation of the purpose of this type of map

Setting expectations

How to read this map

If people still want to understand and use the visual

Service map v1.5



Description of the map

Example: Turning the service map visual into a deck (2)

Linear part of the service

Extra stages that might happen

Name of the stage

25%
text...

High level description

Description of the sequence of tasks and events by different actors

Touchpoints, channels, systems involved

We welcome your feedback

Contact name@dept.gov.uk

Thank you!

Pros and cons of alternative formats

- time consuming
 - need to maintain two formats
- this is **accessible** for people who are colour blind, visually impaired and for some neurodivergent types
- **improve my mapping**
- **more feedback** and engagement from people who are not designers

Design together

But there are no disabled people in my team

→ many disabilities are not visible

Neurodivergence in tech / creative industry:

→ over 20% - probably up to 50%

→ people sometimes don't declare their disability

Things can change

- actual employees can become disabled
- a new joiner might be disabled

→ **Make sure your systems, processes and practice are accessible for all**

Creating a safe space

Do not force people to disclose a disability or medical condition

→ offer help for everyone

Instead of providing accommodations for disabled people

→ offer various options to all

Invite for feedback and allow people to reach out privately

Don't assume you know what is best

People don't have the same needs even if they have the same condition, and **needs vary in different contexts.**

- always best to ask what would help
- have that discussion with the person
- do not assume you're doing the right thing

Manual of me

- help you tell others what you need
- learn about what other people in your team needs

Do not make people share more than they are willing to!

Examples of sections:

- condition I like to work in
- time and hours I like to work
- best way to communicate with me or provide feedback
- things I'm good at
- things I might need help with
- how I like to be helped

Organising/hosting a session

- before the session: set expectations, provide an agenda, do it again at the start of the actual session
- invite people to tell you if this might not work for them
- if using online tools like Mural or Miro, plan for an alternative
- if over an hour → plan for a break and stick to it
- repeat the question someone asked before answering unless you're sure everyone has heard/seen it

Presenting during a session

- share your slides at the start of a presentation or in your invite
- keep content short and simple, test the accessibility of the deck
- use a mic, speak facing your audience, camera on if online
- leave some space at the bottom of your slides
- describe any image/ diagram, assume at least one person cannot see
- don't assume people can read the text on slides

Getting people in a venue

- access to toilets
- enough space to move around
- can the light be controlled
- sitting arrangement - standing
- provide photos or video of the space, and how to get there
- plan more time!

Key takeaways

Designing for everyone

- think about accessibility right from the start
- do not forget about internal users
- consider neurodivergence and low numeracy in particular
- ask for feedback
- focus on: integration with other services, questions, consistency

Design communication

- provide alternative formats for your visuals and maps
- check colour contrast especially for your text
- do not rely on colour alone to convey meaning
- use plain language and explain acronyms
- be careful with numbers
- use accessibility checkers for your slides and word documents
- send your presentation ahead of the meeting

Designing together

- do not assume there are no disabled people in your team
- consider neurodivergence
- do not assume you know what is best
- use manuals of me

Resources

About Accessibility and neurodiversity

- [Past videos \(of the Accessibility Scotland conference\)](#)
- [Inclusive Design 24](#) online and free
- [Public neurodiversity support center](#)
- [The Neurocrats: Civil Service Live podcast](#) on YouTube
- [Estimate how many people using your website might be disabled](#)

Guidances

- [DWP Accessibility manual](#)
- [Accessibility and inclusive design manual](#) from the Department for Education
- Scope: [checking the accessibility of an event or venue](#) and [accessible events toolkit](#)
- [Accessible numbers project](#)
- [Why you need to make your maps accessible](#) - GOV.UK Blog post

Thank you!

To Craig Abbott, Tom Napier, Alice Forward, Lindsay Stephens, Shalom Jesusanmi, Helen Spires, and the whole DWP Service Design Community

And thank you for listening!



Any question?

Get in touch:

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Or on the cross gov Slack